

The Revolt of the Masses

José Ortega y Gasset

First published in 1930, *The Revolt of the Masses* is José Ortega y Gasset's landmark analysis of cultural decline in the age of mass society. Writing in the aftermath of World War I, Ortega observed a profound shift in European life: the ascendancy of the average individual as the dominant social force—confident, entitled, and untethered from inherited standards of excellence.

At the center of the book is the concept of the “mass man”—not defined by class, but by attitude. This is the individual who enjoys the fruits of civilization while disdaining the discipline and minority excellence required to sustain it. Ortega contrasts this figure with the “select minority,” those who demand more of themselves and assume responsibility for cultural direction.

Blending philosophy, sociology, and cultural criticism, Ortega's work remains strikingly relevant in an era shaped by mass media, technocracy, and ideological polarization. His warning is not against democracy itself, but against the erosion of standards, hierarchy, and depth.



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